

aspects.”⁴ The editors of an important contribution to the study of ‘Western esotericism’ (as described above) avoid the term ‘esotericism’ because “it was not used in early modern times” and because “it too easily provokes associations with the contemporary ‘New Age’ movement.”⁵ A third example, discussed below, is Monika Neugebauer-Wölk who limits the applicability of the term to the period between 1450 and 1800.

One argument of this chapter is that ‘esoteric discourse’ is a useful term for addressing structural elements of European culture in historical perspective, structures that include the role of scholarly concepts in the formation of modern Western identities.

Approaches to Esotericism

While the adjective ‘esoteric’ (from Greek *esôterikos*, meaning “the inner”) is first attested in a satire by Lucian of Samosata in the second century CE, its contrasting term ‘exoteric’ was already present in ancient Greek philosophy.⁶ The neologism ‘esotericism,’ however, has a relatively short history.⁷ In its French form *l’ésotérisme* it seems to make its appearance in 1828, in a time when in the wake of the Enlightenment’s religious critique alternative religious currents began to break away from mainstream Christianity. Hence, in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries the idea that esotericism was something different from Christianity gained wide currency. Scholars described the esoteric as some kind of subculture, as a tradition that had formulated alternatives to the Christian mainstream from the Renaissance onwards. Like ‘gnosis’ and ‘mysticism’—in fact often synonyms in earlier scholarship for what today is addressed as esotericism—esoteric currents were regarded as having been suppressed as heretical by orthodox Christianity.⁸ Until the 1950s, the study of these phenomena was dominated by specialists in mysticism and in gnosis who regarded

⁴ Gruber, “Mystik, Esoterik, Okkultismus,” 28.

⁵ Trepp, “Hermetismus oder zur Pluralisierung von Religiositäts- und Wissensformen in der Frühen Neuzeit,” 10.

⁶ See Gaiser, “Platons esoterische Lehre”; Riffard, *L’ésotérisme*, 65.

⁷ See the overview in Hanegraaff, “Esotericism,” 336–337; Riffard, *L’ésotérisme*, 63–137.

⁸ See van den Broek & Hanegraaff (eds.), *Gnosis and Hermeticism*; van den Broek & van Heertum (eds.), *From Poimandres to Jacob Böhme*.

their fields of research as powerful alternatives to the institutionalized scriptural religions of Europe. Many of these scholars—Gershom Scholem, Henry Corbin, Mircea Eliade, Martin Buber, and Carl Gustav Jung—were themselves part of a counter-movement against the ‘disenchantment of the world.’⁹

Let us have a closer look at dominant approaches to Western esotericism today. Following the ancient usages of the term, scholars often referred to the esoteric as something hidden from the majority, as a secret accessible only to a small group of initiates. But many of these teachings had in fact never been concealed, and in the twentieth century they even gained wide currency in popular discourses, so that to characterize esotericism as secretive and elitist seemed to be misleading.¹⁰ This critique of the notion of secrecy, reasonable as it might seem at first glance, has had an unfortunate impact on scholarly research, because it led to a neglect of the discursive function of secrecy. I will return to this issue in more detail below.

A very influential understanding of esotericism was put forward by Antoine Faivre. He claimed that the common denominator, or the *air de famille*, of those currents referred to as esoteric traditions was a specific *form of thought* (French *forme de pensée*); a certain vagueness of this concept notwithstanding,¹¹ Faivre regards the “form of thought” as a characteristic way of approaching and interpreting the world. Faivre developed his characteristics from a certain set of early modern sources that comprise the ‘occult sciences’ (astrology, alchemy, and magic), Neoplatonic and Hermetic thinking as it was shaped in the Renaissance, Christian kabbalah, (mainly Protestant) theosophy, and the notions of a *prisca theologia* or *philosophia perennis*.

In 1992, Faivre put forward his heuristic thesis that the esoteric “form of thought” consists of four “intrinsic,” or indispensable, characteristics, accompanied by two “relative” characteristics, which are not essential but which nevertheless occur very often. Faivre insisted that only those currents are correctly labeled ‘esotericism’ that show

⁹ The famous *Erano*s meetings are an important part of this early stage of research into Western esotericism; see Wasserstrom, *Religion after Religion*; Hakl, *Der verborgene Geist von Erano*s.

¹⁰ See Faivre, “The Notions of Concealment and Secrecy”; Boehinger, “New Age” and *moderne Religion*, 374–375.

¹¹ Cf. the critique in McCalla, “Antoine Faivre and the Study of Esotericism,” 443–444.

all four intrinsic characteristics, even if in different emphases.¹² (1) The idea of correspondences is a crucial characteristic because it refers to the famous Hermetic notion of ‘what is below is like what is above.’ In the wake of the micro-macrocosm idea of ancient philosophy and religion, esotericists view the entire cosmos as a ‘theater of mirrors,’ an ensemble of hieroglyphs to be deciphered by adepts. Astrology, magic, and spiritual alchemy all partake in this kind of interpretation. (2) The concept of *living nature* views nature as a whole as a living being, permeated by an interior light or hidden fire that circulates through it. Nature can be read like a book but also interacted with through active participation, for instance in magical acts (*magia naturalis* in Renaissance parlance). (3) *Imagination and mediations* are complementary notions, referring on the one hand to imagination as an ‘organ of the soul’ and the importance of focused concentration in magical work;¹³ mediation means the contact with intermediary entities that serve as informants and messengers to the absolute truth. The important role of angels, (‘ascended’) masters, or divine figures in the process of revelation can also be described as mediation. (4) The *experience of transmutation* expresses the idea that adepts of esoteric tradition undergo a profound process of transformation and rebirth. Faivre alludes to the alchemical doctrine of death-and-rebirth to illuminate the spiritual processes within the adept.¹⁴ The two “relative” characteristics are (5) *the praxis of concordance*, or the search for reference systems that show the common denominator of all spiritual traditions (similar to the idea of *philosophia perennis*), and (6) the notion of *transmission*, or the initiation of an adept by a teacher or a group.

The past fifteen years have shown that this typological approach, developed from concrete historical material, is very helpful in understanding the connections among seemingly diverse traditions, e.g. the philosophy of nature, mysticism, Hermeticism, gnosis, astrology, magic, and alchemy. In addition, Faivre’s operational definition

¹² See Faivre & Needleman (eds.), *Modern Esoteric Spirituality*, xi–xxx; Faivre, *Access to Western Esotericism*, 1–19.

¹³ The importance of this concept in early modern times is analyzed in Godet, *Imagination*; see also van den Doel & Hanegraaff, “Imagination.”

¹⁴ The difficulties with the notion of ‘spiritual alchemy’ and its use to represent alchemy in general (mainly through the religionist psychology of C.G. Jung) are discussed in Principe & Newman, “Some Problems with the Historiography of Alchemy.”

of esotericism¹⁵ helped to overcome the simplistic dichotomies—of religion versus science, magic versus religion, and esotericism versus Enlightenment—that had so often distorted earlier understandings of the complexities of Western culture.¹⁶ At the same time, it is a characteristic of heuristic, operational definitions that they are subject to critique and change. One problem is the fact that Faivre does not always consistently employ his own typology. On the one hand, he describes currents as esoteric that do not fit all of his characteristics (e.g. Mesmerism, which shows only one characteristic, namely the idea of living nature); on the other hand, he excludes currents that nicely match his typology but fall beyond his scope of interest, such as Suhrawardī's medieval Islamic philosophy. More importantly, Faivre generates his typology from a limited set of sources—originating mainly from Renaissance Hermeticism, *Naturphilosophie*, Christian kabbalah, and Christian theosophy—and thus deliberately excludes aspects of European history of religion that other scholars view as decisive for a contextual understanding of esoteric currents.¹⁷ In doing so, he excludes antiquity, the medieval period, and above all modernity.¹⁸ He marginalizes Jewish, Muslim and 'pagan' traditions as mere influences on 'esotericism proper.' In a review of my work, Faivre writes:

Actually, Faivre's intention had just been to speak, as a methodological choice, of an 'occident visited by Judaism and Islam,' therefore mainly immersed (until the twentieth century) in Christianity. This did not mean, by the same token, underrating the importance of a religious pluralism, the reality of which, after all, nobody would (or could) deny.¹⁹

¹⁵ See McCalla, "Antoine Faivre and the Study of Esotericism," 443.

¹⁶ Cf. also Neugebauer-Wölk & Zaunstöck (eds.), *Aufklärung und Esoterik*; Neugebauer-Wölk & Rudolph (eds.), *Aufklärung und Esoterik*.

¹⁷ On Faivre's arguments against a "comparative study of esotericism" that runs the risk of claiming a universal—essentialist—esotericism see Faivre, "La question d'un ésotérisme comparé des religions du livre," particularly 102–105; but cf. Hanegraaff, "Empirical Method in the Study of Esotericism," 121–124.

¹⁸ 'Correspondences,' for instance, have a different meaning in the Renaissance than in twentieth-century magic. Another problematic term is 'magic': Wouter J. Hanegraaff ("How Magic Survived the Disenchantment of the World") compared the Renaissance *magia naturalis* and the 'disenchanted magic' of the twentieth century (cf. the critical remarks in Asprem, "Magic Naturalized?"). As a conclusion, simple typological approaches to this shifting field of identities and strategies miss the point because they pretend a common denominator that is not found in the sources.

¹⁹ Faivre, "Kocku von Stuckrad et la notion d'ésotérisme," 208 (italics original).

Calling Judaism and Islam “visitors” of Christian Europe is a highly problematic notion, to say the least; it reveals a Christian-normative understanding of European history of religion, which I critically engaged above. This statement also shows that Faivre has completely misread my very concept of pluralism, which is based on the critical function of the Other for sustaining one’s own identity. More important, though, is the fact that such a view on the relevance of Judaism and Islam for Western esotericism has been influential. For instance, the already mentioned *Dictionary of Gnosis and Western Esotericism*, a flagship publication in the field, also marginalizes Jewish and Islamic esotericism. Even if we take into account the “pragmatic reasons” the editor Wouter J. Hanegraaff gives for these lacunae,²⁰ it remains strange that the Jewish authors and currents are lumped together in the lemma “Jewish Influences”; Islamic ‘influences’ are not even covered in a respective entry. It may be argued that this is not only a pragmatic decision but also evidence of a discursive event, even if the editors are not aware of the discourse they are exerting.

If we follow Faivre’s typology, we end up in a circular argument: “since esotericism is defined as a form of thought, nothing outside that form of thought can be esotericism.”²¹ Although he himself would disagree, Faivre’s typology in fact best fits what could be called Christian esotericism in the early modern period or, to borrow Neugebauer-Wölk’s phrase, “Western esotericism in a Christian context.”²² Antoine Faivre’s enormous effort for the establishment of the field notwithstanding, there are almost no scholars today who apply Faivre’s typology without significant changes and adjustments. Thus, alternative interpretations of esotericism have been suggested. Among these, Monika Neugebauer-Wölk’s and Wouter J. Hanegraaff’s deserve special attention.

In a nuanced exploration of methodological issues, Monika Neugebauer-Wölk argues for a distinction between esotericism and Christianity. She contends that esotericism should be defined as an *alternative* to Christianity that cannot be integrated into Christian semantic structures. To address early modern esotericism as an “independent

²⁰ Hanegraaff, “Introduction,” xii.

²¹ McCalla, “Antoine Faivre and the Study of Esotericism,” 444.

²² Neugebauer-Wölk, “Esoterik und Christentum vor 1800,” 160. Faivre’s religionist language—particularly in his early writings—is pointed out by McCalla, “Antoine Faivre and the Study of Esotericism,” 444–447.

religious system of meaning" (*Sinnsystem*)—that is, independent of Christianity²³—she identifies five characteristics, or thematic fields (*Themenkreise*), of esotericism that demonstrate its autonomy.²⁴ (1) The "transgression of holy scriptures" refers to the fact that esoteric authors often claim knowledge that is revealed from non-Christian sources, such as the *Corpus Hermeticum*, the Chaldaean Oracles, and some pre-Christian traditions. (2) These claims lead to the idea of a "higher knowledge" within esoteric discourse. Early modern esotericism understands itself as "true Christianity" on the basis of higher knowledge.²⁵ (3) "Realization and worldly power" addresses the claim to put esoteric knowledge into social and political practice, thus challenging the institutionalized forms of Christianity. According to Neugebauer-Wölk, this claim should not be mixed up with the real historical exertion of power in Christian institutions, because Christianity had to "broaden and adjust" its religious concepts in order to justify power, while the exertion of power is "an integral part of esoteric religiosity." (4) The practical aspect of esotericism has implications for ideas of "revelation and the image of Christ." It is particularly the gnostic notion of self-redemption,²⁶ the identification of Christ with the alchemical *Opus Magnum*, and the "repeated reincarnations of the Son of God" that are "incompatible with the Christian system of meaning." (5) Finally, the idea of "invisible church and secret society" constitutes a powerful alternative to the public nature of both church and society in institutionalized Christianity.

Neugebauer-Wölk understands her model as an ideal type. It "follows the intention to put forward a religious *conception*, i.e. to paradigmatically distinguish esotericism from Christianity, not esotericists from Christians."²⁷ And she limits her interpretation to the period between 1450 and 1800, which means that if we want to arrive at a general concept of esotericism, this model is of only restricted applicability. But even with regard to that period methodological questions remain. Is it correct to identify Christianity with the confessional-

²³ Neugebauer-Wölk, "Esoterik und Christentum vor 1800," 137.

²⁴ *Ibid.*, 137–143.

²⁵ The problem how the claim to represent "true Christianity" should characterize esotericism as being *outside* Christianity, remains unresolved in Neugebauer-Wölk's approach.

²⁶ One may add that in gnosticism even the divinity is saved, while in mainstream Christianity it is humans who are being saved.

²⁷ Neugebauer-Wölk, "Esoterik und Christentum vor 1800," 143, *italics original*.

ized and institutionalized churches?²⁸ Are we not confronted with an *internal pluralization* of Christianity, a process in which alternative readings of Christian tradition claim authority (the “true church”)?²⁹ Even taken as an ideal-typical point of departure, it may be argued that Neugebauer-Wölk’s model is the manifestation of a theological discourse of purity and difference.³⁰ The crucial problem of this Christian-normative approach is the neglect of non-Christian traditions in Western culture. Even if we accept Neugebauer-Wölk’s first two characteristics, we will have to remove the focus on Christianity as decisive for esoteric discourse.³¹

Let us have a look at yet another important contribution to the academic study of Western esotericism. In recent publications, Wouter J. Hanegraaff has developed his idea of a “Grand Polemical Narrative” that according to him underlies the formation of the set of currents that today is regarded as esotericism by most scholars. As he put it in 2005:

[T]he field of study referred to as ‘Western esotericism’ is the historical product of a polemical discourse, the dynamics of which can be traced all the way back to the beginnings of monotheism. Moreover, it is in the terms of this very same discourse that mainstream Western culture has been construing its own identity, up to the present day. This process of the construction of identity takes place by means of telling stories—to ourselves and to others—of who, what and how we want to be. The challenge of the modern study of Western esotericism to academic research ultimately consists in the fact that it questions and undermines those stories, and forces us to see who, what and how we really *are*. Instinctive resistance against the breaking down of certainties implicit in such (self)knowledge is at the very root of traditional academic resistance against the study of Western esotericism.³²

²⁸ This idea is criticized by Hanegraaff, “The Dreams of Theology and the Realities of Christianity,” to which Neugebauer-Wölk reacts in her article.

²⁹ Neugebauer-Wölk sees the problem without giving a solution to it: “The main problem of the approach proposed here, namely to basically differentiate esotericism and Christianity, is the self-understanding of the contemporaries” (“Esoterik und Christentum vor 1800,” 159).

³⁰ Neugebauer-Wölk correctly criticizes the full inclusion of esotericism into Christianity as taking sides with the early modern esotericists who claim to be (true) Christians; but taking sides with “the orthodoxies of that epoch” (*ibid.*, 160) seems to me equally problematic.

³¹ See also Lehmann, “Probleme einer Europäischen Religionsgeschichte der Frühen Neuzeit,” 235–237.

³² Hanegraaff, “Forbidden Knowledge,” 226, italics original.

This focus on the reconstruction of the genealogy of what today is referred to as esotericism comes very close to my own understanding of what the field of esotericism research is all about. I agree with Hanegraaff that polemics and identities are at the core of esoteric discourses, and that when we study ‘esotericism’ we will have to address these dynamics. However, I differ from Hanegraaff on three points: First of all, I do not think that the dynamics of such a polemical discourse “can be traced all the way back to the beginnings of monotheism”; rather, what we see at work is an old dialectic of fascination and rejection that gave way to a disjunctive mechanism only after the scientific revolution and the Enlightenment. Second, I do not think that historiography will ever be able to tell us “what and how we really *are*”;³³ in fact, such an essentialist narrative is not what historians should be willing to provide. Perhaps we are just telling *other* “stories—to ourselves and to others—of who, what and how we want to be.”³⁴ Third, in my view it is discourse analysis that would provide a useful referential framework for Hanegraaff’s position.

Let me explain this contention in more detail. Hanegraaff bases his analysis on the concept of “mnemohistory” (*Gedächtnisgeschichte*) that Jan Assmann has developed.³⁵ The concept of mnemohistory is applied to an analytical distinction, which Hanegraaff calls a “complex pattern of cultural and religious interactions based upon a ‘deep structure’ of conflict between the dynamics of two mutually exclusive systems: monotheism and cosmotheism, and all that they imply. The logical incompatibility of the two systems has led to an endless series of creative attempts to overcome it.”³⁶ Hanegraaff thus is turning away from typological approaches based on content and ideas and explores the *structures* that underlie European history of culture. I fully agree that this approach opens new vistas for inquiry. The question is, whether the construction of a “Grand Polemical Narrative” is helpful, or coherent.

³³ See also his claim that “as a matter of historical fact paganism is and always has been part of what we *are*” (Hanegraaff, “Forbidden Knowledge,” 234, italics original).

³⁴ See chapter 10 for a critique of this normative realist position.

³⁵ On the differences between Assmann and Hanegraaff see Hanegraaff, “The Trouble with Images,” 112.

³⁶ Hanegraaff, “The Trouble with Images,” 120. In that article, Hanegraaff focuses particularly on the concept of idolatry and the discourse of images.

To begin with, falling back on Assmann's conceptualization of monotheistic and "cosmotheistic" mnemohistory comes with a price. The problem here is the vague differentiation, inherent in Assmann's interpretation, between historical data and tools of interpretation. Although mnemohistory is presented as independent of actual historical developments, its initial introduction, according to Assmann, is directly linked to historical instances, from the first monotheistic concepts of Akhenaton to the supposed imposition of exclusive monotheism by biblical Judaism.³⁷ It is controversial, to say the least, whether this description does correspond to the actual historical development. Peter Schäfer calls Assmann's exclusive monotheism an exaggerated straw man "that historically never existed."³⁸

But even if we accept that mnemohistory is independent from actual history—and both Assmann and Hanegraaff argue that the origins of the distinction between monotheism and cosmotheism, and the origins of the mnemohistorical idea of that history, do not coincide—there must be sufficient historical evidence for the existence of such a memory.³⁹ However, many of the 'currents' within the field of Western esotericism (however defined) have in fact never been simply neglected, marginalized, or banned as dangerous (and thus, 'remembered' negatively); they all have a complex and changing history in many different contexts.⁴⁰ If there is an effective polemical Othering in Western history, this process unfolded as late as during the eighteenth through twentieth centuries. Wouter Hanegraaff himself hints at this process:

³⁷ The idea is developed in Assmann, *Die mosaische Unterscheidung*.

³⁸ "Die Kategorie des Monotheismus, die Assmann postuliert, ist eine Abstraktion bzw. genauer ein Popanz, den es historisch so nie gegeben hat und dessen gedächtnisgeschichtlicher Wert außerordentlich zweifelhaft ist" (Schäfer, "Geschichte und Gedächtnisgeschichte," 22–23). Schäfer also notes the anti-Semitic potential—of course unintended by Assmann—of the distinction between 'monotheism' and 'cosmotheism' ("eine historische Fiktion, die auch gedächtnisgeschichtlich nicht gerettet werden kann"; p. 24; see also pp. 25–39). A critical Egyptological response to Assmann's assumptions is presented by Quack, "Perspektiven zur Theologie im Alten Ägypten." Cf. also Bergunder, "'Östliche' Religionen und Gewalt," as a critique of Assmann.

³⁹ This problem is noted by Schäfer, "Geschichte und Gedächtnisgeschichte," 21–22.

⁴⁰ This is true for Hermeticism, astrology, alchemy, freemasonry, or kabbalah. Even for natural magic a more nuanced picture has to be applied.